creative thinking instead of fear or paralysis. India and China must learn to co-exist in the Indo-Pacific and the world; otherwise, their progress will stall. India wants to engage China in rules and conventions of behaviour that emphasise the primacy of international law, not the primacy of one nation above others, as the cornerstone for developing a security architecture in Asia.

Notwithstanding the challenges, the Indo-Pacific region, composed largely of Asian countries, might slowly evolve a model of cooperative security. An Asian security order is required for the cooperative management of its commons, including its oceans. An Asian order, by definition, cannot be exclusivist and must be open, inclusive, plural, transparent, flexibly structured, and based on predictable behaviour. This is not an impossible task, but in terms of a security architecture for such an order, we are in the pre-evolutionary phase of this exercise. Just as Asian countries have devised inventive models of economic growth and accelerated their transformation faster than previously attempted, so they could conceive of ways of managing their security cooperatively. Asians should not be diffident about such an outcome.

Historically, Asia has had a model of cooperative regionalism, at the time of the Srivijaya Empire, founded in 680 AD in Sumatra, that lasted about four and a half centuries. Polycentric and dispersed, it encompassed the Indonesian Archipelago and the Malay Peninsula. A Sino-Indic confluence in Southeast Asia existed at the time. A similar confluence, this time wider and more embracing of other powers, can be the basis of a new Asian order, but only on the condition that the idea of regional hegemonism is well and truly buried.

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